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Design Thinking

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Freedom of Expression at Dartmouth

Guidelines for the User Interview:

- Set up interviews with people who are central to your topic. Use your notebooks and video to capture details (make sure to get consent before recording!). Ask for stories. Follow up with “why” questions to move between emotional experiences/needs and tangible things/actions. After your first few interviews, evaluate your questions and responses. Refine questions to get deeper insights.
- Carefully select whom you should interview to get the info you need, and reach out early. (It can take some time to get on people’s calendars). Don’t just interview your friends. Get out there and talk to people who really understand and care about your topic. These people can include faculty, staff, and administrators.

Interview Questions:

- Could you introduce yourself?
- How has your experience of expressing your opinions been at Dartmouth? Could you bring a particular example?
- What’s your opinion on the Dartmouth Dialogue Project?
- Is Dartmouth practicing “brave space”?
- What would you wish to see for enhancing Dartmouth students expressing their freedom of speech and expression?

Interview Notes, 18/5 and 19/5:

Person 1 - Student:

- I’m a ‘28 studying Comparative Literature, and I’m involved with the Palestine Solidarity Coalition at Dartmouth.
- My experience of expressing opinions and freedom of speech has been mixed. It’s a small school, where everyone knows each other. And if you happen to be present in protests,

opponents walk away from you. There's a lot of fear circulating around financial funding being cut from Dartmouth, so demanding free speech could be a big risk for the administration. One example is, on May 1st we had a non-violent encampment in front of the Administration that it took so long for them to respond to our needs.

- The Dartmouth Dialogue Project isn't very effective in freedom of expression; I think, it's a lot of talking and dialogues, which most students are afraid of. President Beilock encourages this project, but it's hard for her to show up in cases of encampment or protests.
- To some extent, yes. In classrooms, we are free to express our political opinions. Though we are not always talking about politics, so if it's not relevant to the class, we rarely talk about, let's say, encampments on the Green or the Trump administration.
- I wish Dartmouth administration could ask students what they want to see happening in policies.

Person 2 - Student:

- I'm a Gov student, and I'm a '27 very interested in American politics, especially in regards to the U.S. policy in the Middle East.
- It's mildly hopeful. I mean, I'm more open to say what I believe in and I express what my demands and needs are pretty openly among my peers. But when it comes to talking to someone in a hierarchical role like a professor, I step back. I don't want to be looked upon because of my political views, though I also think studentship and politics are inseparable. As someone participated in the encampment last year on the Green and was arrested, it was worse at that time. The administration put little effort in hearing us. Right now it's somewhat better, and I think it's due to the fact that the administration wants to calm things down without the eyes of the Trump administration.
- The Dartmouth Dialogue Project is like a small circle of people having discussions. But what can we take away from it? Can we implement suggestions that students made? They don't ask these questions, and that's what bothers me.
- It's ambiguous what "brave space" means, to be honest. Brave space exists but only in certain situations.
- I wish there could be direct communication between the administration and students.

Person 3 - Student:

- Engineering track from Maine.
- It has been mixed. My dad is a republican and it's hard to bring such perspectives, and it feels 'too liberal' sometimes.
- I've never participated in it, but I heard good things about it. I think best conversations happen when they're most unexpected, rather than a structured discussion.
- It's a brave space where I've not felt limited to express my opinions, but when it comes to political views... It's quite mixed.
- I wish there could be more open discussions, especially during the elections and other major political events.

Person 4 - Faculty:

- I teach at the Middle Eastern department, and I'm involved with the Dickey Center organizing events around politics and the Middle East.
- As a faculty member, we have little control over what policies are being made to enhance free speech at Dartmouth. For example, Beilock's decision not to sign the letter came as a surprise to many of us. It's encouraged that we don't participate in political movements or protests, especially concerning our job positions.
- I know little about the Dartmouth Dialogue Project, because it's usually intended for students (and I don't know whether students actively participate in it?). Many people say that Dartmouth was the first Ivy to put up such an initiative; however, I don't really see the fruits yet. There's still political separation on campus.
- Somewhat, yes. It's questionable what "brave space" means or contains. Does it mean being able to bravely express what your political views are? Does it also mean having the right to stand up for what you believe in? Or, does it have limitations? It's not very clear.
- I wish Dartmouth students took some time to pause from their hectic school and extracurricular life. I understand that a 10-week term makes it incredibly difficult, but topics of liberation, freedom of speech and expression, and human rights are also important and shouldn't be overlooked amongst less important life matters.

Person 5 - Faculty:

- I teach at the Comparative Literature department and I regularly attend peaceful protests.
- A very recent example is from a rally in front of the Administration on May 1st. It had a lot of nuances, but we fortunately managed to bring some changes, like increasing funds for affected international students.
- I think it's a helpful project for students to raise their voice for a positive change. However, lately it's been quiet and I don't hear much about it anymore.
- I wouldn't want my students to be restrained from taking classes with me just because of my political views, so I guess a brave space makes one comfortable with no regards to politics.
- I wish there could be a tool or an initiative that can bridge the gap between students and the administration.

Person 6 - Student:

- I'm a junior, and I've been an activist all my time here at Dartmouth.
- I would say, it's been getting better than previous years. Previously, we did hunger strikes and encampments for the administration to get back to us like in almost five days. Especially after last May, this year is definitely less problematic.
- As someone who's been here for quite a while, I think the Dartmouth Dialogue fails in many ways to bring students together. We could discuss for hours about what's happening, but what about the role Dartmouth plays in it? I'm very much against the president Beilock's decision.

- 'Brave space' does exist at Dartmouth, but it's been used so many times that it loses actual meaning.
- I wish students could interact with their professors around current topics outside classes. I wish something existed that could bring them together (apart from the Take Your Professor To Lunch program).